



When the Hallway Wakes: Poetry Word-Choice Lab

Grade 7 • North Carolina • Poetry / reading

RL.7.4

Interpret figurative language and analyze how specific words shape meaning and tone. Includes 16 practice tasks, a four-task exit check, two explained models, and complete answer guidance.

PRINT • TEACH • REVISIT



Plan a focused lesson

Level and alignment

Grade 7 • North Carolina • Poetry / reading; RL.7.4. Focus: Interpret figurative language and analyze how specific words shape meaning and tone.

What is included

One cover; one teacher guide; one mini-lesson with two explained models; 2 original text/reference section(s); 16 practice tasks on four pages; one four-task exit check; four answer-key pages covering all 20 tasks; two access/source/license pages. Student texts are original, not extracted from released tests.

Time and sequence

Two 30–40-minute sessions plus a 10–15-minute exit check; extended writing or speech rehearsal may take longer. Model first; use tasks 1–4 to check readiness; practice the remainder in short groups; give tasks 17–20 without the key.

Preparation

Print student pages separately from teacher pages. Provide pencils and extra paper; oral-response learners need an adult recorder. Review word meanings and prerequisite decoding or sentence skills. No paid app, novel, or external reading is required.

Student directions

Read the lesson and supplied text or reference. Attempt each task before viewing the key. Explain when asked. Use separate paper for full drafts or longer answers; the PDF is not a fillable form.



Learn the move

Name a device only after interpreting its meaning. Explain what a word adds that a neutral substitute would lose. Tone is the speaker's attitude, not merely the reader's feeling. These original short poems are focused teaching texts, not full-length EOG simulations. The released EOG form informed text-dependent question design; no released content is reproduced.

Model 1 • “The clock scolded the silent room.” Explain, then name the device.

Ticking seems accusatory or impatient; giving a clock a human action is personification. Scolded creates tension.

Model 2 • Replace scolded with ticked. What changes?

The literal action remains, but the blaming/impatient attitude largely disappears.

Try the task first. Then compare the reasoning, not just the final word.



A. Before the Bell

[1] The hallway holds its breath at dawn.
[2] A broom whispers along the floor.
[3] My unfinished question rides my tongue,
[4] a folded kite beside a door.

[5] Then sneakers scatter little storms;
[6] bright voices loosen every knot.
[7] I lift my hand, release the string—
[8] the question flies from its small spot.



B. After the Fair

[1] The gym exhales its paper stars.

[2] We stack the chairs in patient rows.

[3] A ribbon sleeps beside the door;

[4] nobody hurries when we close.

[5] One crooked sign remains on tape,

[6] still pointing toward an empty stand.

[7] I smooth its corner, fold it twice,

[8] and carry evening in my hand.



Practice • Read, reason, respond

Read the lesson and supplied text or reference. Attempt each task before viewing the key. Explain when asked. Use separate paper for full drafts or longer answers; the PDF is not a fillable form.

1. A1: Explain “holds its breath.”

2. A2: What does whispers suggest about the broom sound?

3. A3–4: What is compared to a folded kite?

4. A5: Explain “little storms.”



Practice • Read, reason, respond

Read the lesson and supplied text or reference. Attempt each task before viewing the key. Explain when asked. Use separate paper for full drafts or longer answers; the PDF is not a fillable form.

5. A6: What might “knots” represent?

6. A7-8: Explain the extended kite image.

7. A: How does tone shift between stanzas?

8. A2: Replace whispers with pounds. How would tone change?



Practice • Read, reason, respond

Read the lesson and supplied text or reference. Attempt each task before viewing the key. Explain when asked. Use separate paper for full drafts or longer answers; the PDF is not a fillable form.

9. B1: Explain “exhales.”

10. B2: What does patient add to rows?

11. B3: Explain ribbon sleeps.

12. B6: How does empty affect the scene?



Practice • Read, reason, respond

Read the lesson and supplied text or reference. Attempt each task before viewing the key. Explain when asked. Use separate paper for full drafts or longer answers; the PDF is not a fillable form.

13. B8: Interpret “carry evening in my hand.”

14. Compare the connotations of scatter in A and stack in B.

15. Which poem feels more reflective? Support an interpretation.

16. Write two sentences linking one device to the poem’s meaning.



Exit check • Apply the skill

Try without the answer key. Show evidence or reasoning when asked. Use separate paper for longer responses.

17. A4: Why folded rather than flying at this point?

18. B2: Replace patient with rigid. Explain the difference.

19. Name a word supporting each poem's tone and explain it.

20. Write a 3–4-sentence analysis of how A's kite image develops.



Answers and response criteria

1. Hallway is quiet and expectant before activity; personification, not literal breathing.
2. Soft, low movement; quieter than scrapes/crashes.
3. The unspoken/unfinished question, waiting to be released.
4. Busy, noisy movement of students; metaphor, not actual weather.
5. Nervousness or difficulty speaking; voices ease tension in context.

Accept equivalent correct answers and well-supported interpretations. Sample writing is guidance, not a required script.



Answers and response criteria

6. Lifting a hand/asking releases the question like a kite; image develops from folded to flying.

7. From quiet hesitation/anticipation to lively confidence; cite breath/unfinished versus lift/flies.

8. More loud/forceful or harsh; soft quiet atmosphere would weaken.

9. The gym seems to release energy after the event; personification suggests winding down.

10. Calm, unhurried order; gives the arrangement an almost human quality.

Accept equivalent correct answers and well-supported interpretations. Sample writing is guidance, not a required script.



Answers and response criteria

11. Ribbon lies still/unused; personification reinforces rest after activity.
12. Emphasizes the event is over and people/items have left; supports quiet reflection.
13. The folded sign carries a memory or trace of the evening; cannot literally hold the time of day.
14. Scatter suggests lively dispersal; stack suggests orderly cleanup; actions support contrasting energy.
15. B, with no hurry, empty stand, and carefully folded sign; accept nuanced alternative with strong evidence.

Accept equivalent correct answers and well-supported interpretations. Sample writing is guidance, not a required script.



Answers and response criteria

16. Require accurate figurative interpretation plus effect on speaking/growing confidence in A or closure/memory in B.

17. Question is still unspoken; folded prepares for the later release.

18. Rigid suggests stiffness/strictness; patient suggests calm waiting.

19. A flies: confidence/freedom; B sleeps: rest. Any justified pairing accepted.

20. Trace folded question to loosened knots/lift/release/flies, explain transition from hesitation to expression, cite line details.

Accept equivalent correct answers and well-supported interpretations. Sample writing is guidance, not a required script.



Access and next teaching steps

AIG

Ask for a counterexample, an alternative supported interpretation, or a newly written item with an explanation. Add depth rather than speed.

504

Follow the individual plan: breaks, enlarged print, extra time, reduced copying, or an alternative response method as documented. These are classroom options, not a statement of permitted test accommodations.

EC

Follow the IEP; show one task at a time, model the first decision, and permit dictated reasoning when appropriate. For decoding practice, distinguish an adult-read direction from an adult-read target word.

ESL

Preview task verbs and key vocabulary, allow home-language planning, and offer “My answer is ___ because ___.” Evaluate the targeted skill separately from unrelated language errors. For French, retain the target French sentence while explaining directions in a familiar language.

Use the exit evidence

For each exit task, record 2 = accurate and complete for the stated prompt; 1 = partly accurate or missing a requested explanation; 0 = not yet demonstrated. Total 0–8 is a local teaching note, not a standardized score. For oral tasks do not penalize spelling or handwriting. Revisit the exact type of error rather than assigning a diagnostic label.

Next lesson: model one missed decision, let the learner try a new example, and compare the explanation. Extend only after the learner can explain the targeted skill.

Alignment, sources, and license

The objective is original wording describing a focused part of the cited standard; this is not a full curriculum or official practice test. NCDPI states the 2017 ELA standards apply in 2026–27; the 2026 revision begins in 2027–28. Released-form review informed text-dependent item design only.

Official state standard • accessed September 15, 2026

<https://www.dpi.nc.gov/documents/publications/catalog/cm205-gr7-understandingelascos/open>

NCDPI EOG released reading form (structure review only) • accessed September 15, 2026

<https://www.dpi.nc.gov/documents/accountability/testing/eog/eog-reading-grade-7-released-form/open>

NCDPI ELA implementation schedule • accessed September 15, 2026

<https://www.dpi.nc.gov/districts-schools/classroom-resources/office-teaching-and-learning/standard-course-study/english-language-arts/standard-course-study-supporting-resources>

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